Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

Phase-Wise Detailed Report with Output Screenshots

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Phase 1 – Requirement Analysis & Planning

Before any configuration begins, the project starts with a structured planning exercise. This phase establishes why the workflow is being built, what it must functionally cover, who is involved in delivering and using it, and in what order the remaining work will be executed.

The sub-sections below break this planning work into four deliverables: the business objectives driving the project, the functional scope that bounds it, the stakeholders who shaped it, and the execution roadmap that sequences the phases that follow.

1.1 Business Objectives

The core business objective is to give the support organization a single, standardized way to log, investigate, and resolve service disruptions so that no incident is handled inconsistently depending on who picks it up or which channel it arrived through.

A second objective is to shorten resolution time by surfacing existing knowledge at the point of classification, so agents are not repeating diagnostic work that has already been solved and documented for a similar issue.

A third objective is to keep every change to production infrastructure controlled and auditable, even when that change is being made urgently to resolve an active incident, by routing it through a formal Emergency Change process rather than an informal fix.

Implementation Highlights

- Standardize incident handling across intake channels
- Reduce resolution time through knowledge reuse
- Keep infrastructure changes controlled and auditable
- Preserve a complete record for reporting and audit

1.2 Functional Scope

The functional scope covers the full path an incident travels through ServiceNow: creation and classification, knowledge suggestion, reassignment and escalation to Level 2, coordination with Change Management when infrastructure must be modified, linking of related child incidents, resolution and cause documentation, and conversion of the resolution into reusable knowledge.

It also covers the supporting CMDB configuration — the Business Service and Service Offering records — that every incident in scope is associated with, since accurate service mapping is what makes classification, routing, and reporting meaningful.

Explicitly out of scope for this phase of the project is any work on Problem Management or Major Incident Management processes; the workflow here is scoped to standard incident handling with an emergency-change dependency.

Implementation Highlights

- In scope: incident creation through knowledge publication
- In scope: supporting CMDB service/offering structure
- In scope: emergency change coordination
- Out of scope: Problem and Major Incident processes

1.3 Stakeholder Mapping

The Service Desk, represented in this walkthrough by agent Beth Anglin, is the first point of contact and needs a fast, low-friction way to log an incident and identify when it should be escalated rather than worked at Level 1.

Level 2 support, represented by David Loo, needs complete diagnostic context handed to them at the point of escalation — classification, prior work notes, and any knowledge already attempted — so investigation can begin immediately rather than starting from zero.

The end user, represented by caller Michael Hoefer, needs visibility into progress and a timely resolution, while IT management needs SLA compliance data and evidence that resolutions are being converted into reusable knowledge.

Implementation Highlights

- Service Desk: fast intake and accurate escalation
- Level 2 Support: full diagnostic context on handoff
- End User: progress visibility and timely resolution
- IT Management: SLA and knowledge-reuse reporting

1.4 Execution Roadmap

With objectives, scope, and stakeholders defined, the remaining work is sequenced into the phases that make up the rest of this report: CMDB setup, incident intake and classification, knowledge integration, escalation, Level 2 investigation, emergency change coordination, child incident linkage, resolution, knowledge creation, final validation, and end-to-end testing.

This sequence mirrors the actual order in which a real VPN connectivity incident moves through the system, which is why the same Remote Access / Corporate VPN scenario is used consistently as the running example across every later phase.

Implementation Highlights

- Roadmap follows the real order an incident travels through the system
- Each phase in this report builds on the output of the one before it
- Same Remote Access / Corporate VPN scenario used throughout

Phase 2 – Create New Service & Service Offering

With planning complete, the first configuration work happens in the CMDB, where the service structure that every later incident will be associated with is established. This phase covers two milestones: creating the parent Business Service, and creating the Service Offering beneath it.

2.1 Milestone 1: Create New Service

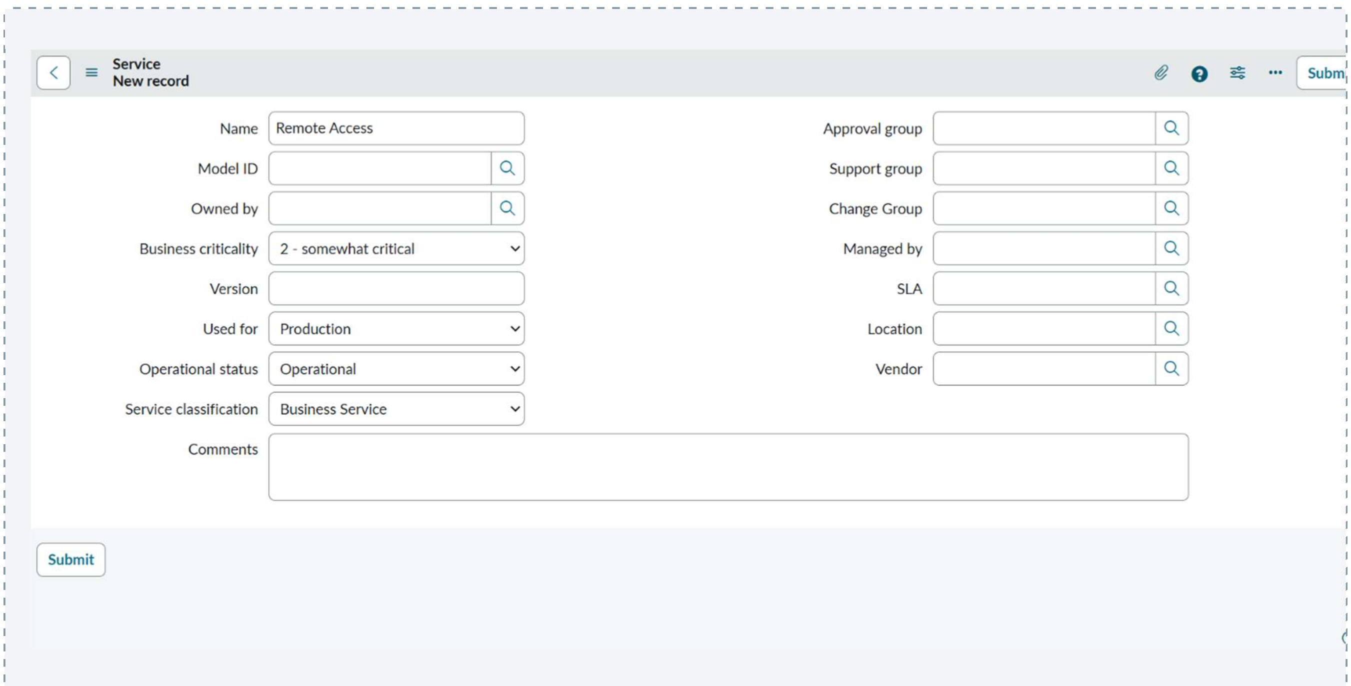
The Remote Access Business Service is created in the CMDB as the parent record representing the organization's VPN capability as a whole. Core fields completed at this step include the service name, owning support group, and operational status.

Creating this record first is what allows every downstream incident, service offering, and configuration item to be traced back to a single, reportable service, rather than being scattered across unrelated CI records.

Implementation Highlights

- Business Service record created: Remote Access
- Owning support group and operational status set
- Acts as the parent record for all related offerings and CIs

Output



2.2 Milestone 2: Create New Service Offering

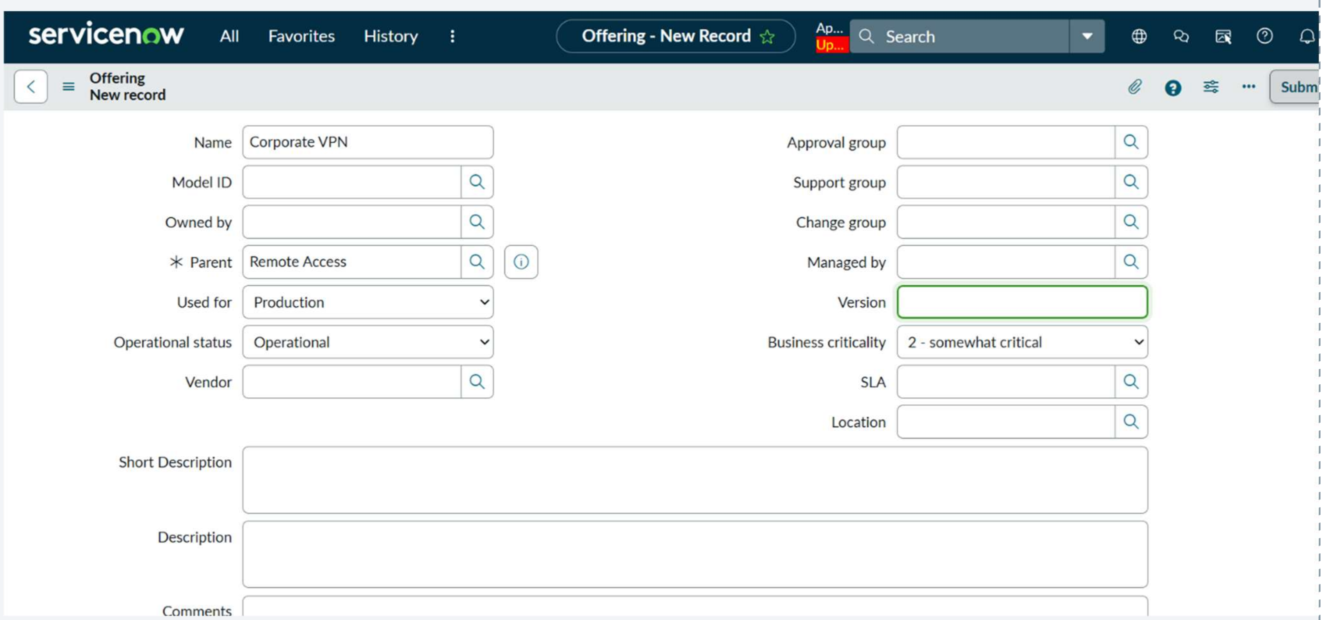
The Corporate VPN Service Offering is created beneath the Remote Access Business Service, representing the specific variant of VPN access being delivered to corporate users, as distinct from any contractor or partner offering that might carry a different SLA definition.

The offering is linked back to its parent service, which completes the CMDB structure needed for every later incident against the VPN to be automatically associated with the correct service and offering.

Implementation Highlights

- Service Offering record created: Corporate VPN
- Linked to the Remote Access parent Business Service
- SLA definitions associated with the offering

Output



Phase 3 – Incident Record Creation

With the service structure in place, the workflow moves to the point where a real disruption is reported and logged as an incident record

3.1 Creating Incident Record

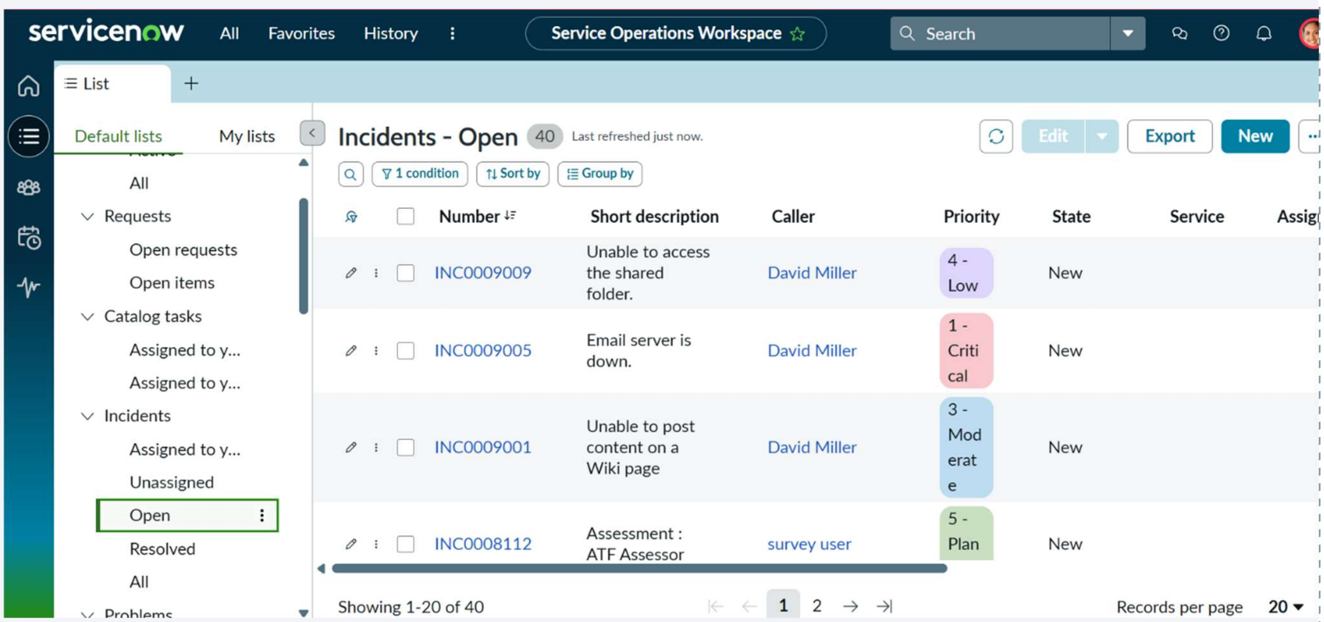
Service Desk agent Beth Anglin logs the incident on behalf of caller Michael Hoefer, who has reported that he is unable to connect to the Corporate VPN. The form captures the caller, a short description of the symptom, and the channel through which the issue was reported.

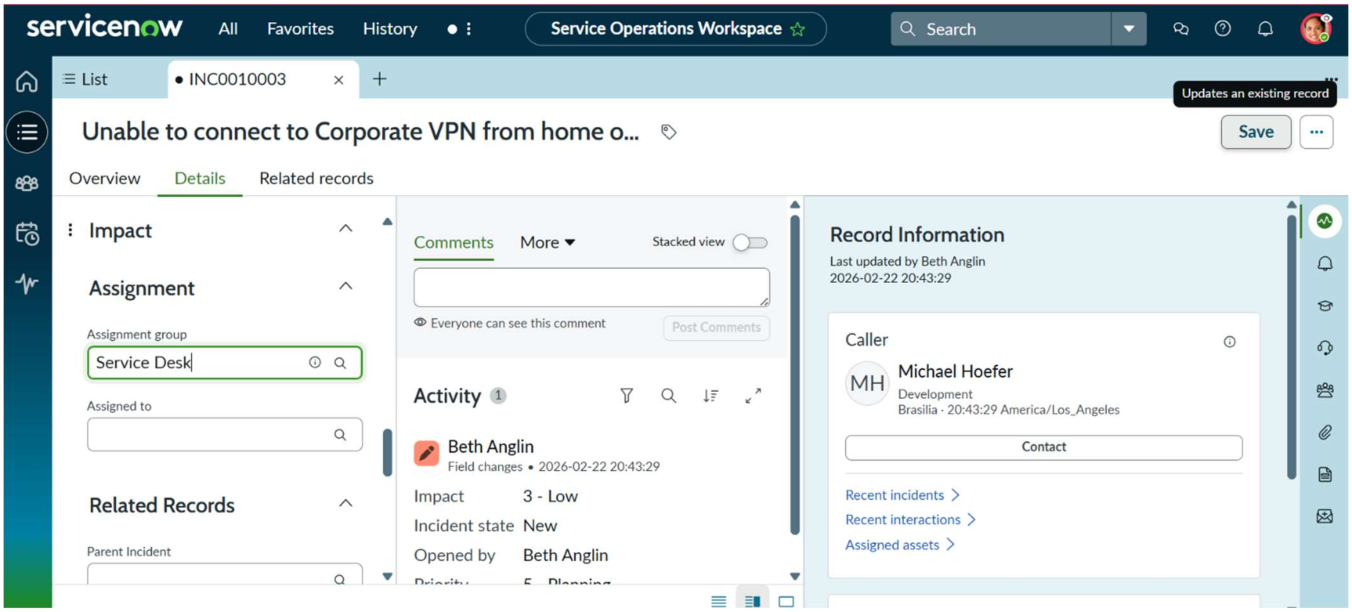
The moment the record is saved, ServiceNow assigns an incident number and begins Task SLA tracking automatically, starting the response and resolution clocks based on the priority calculated from impact and urgency.

Implementation Highlights

- Caller: Michael Hoefer; logged by agent Beth Anglin
- Short description captures the VPN connectivity issue
- Incident number auto-generated on save
- Task SLA tracking begins immediately at creation

Output

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Favorites
History
Service Operations Workspace
Search
List
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Updates an existing record
Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from home o...
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Impact
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Service Desk
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Comments
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Everyone can see this comment
Post Comments
Activity
Beth Anglin
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Incident state New
Opened by Beth Anglin
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Last updated by Beth Anglin
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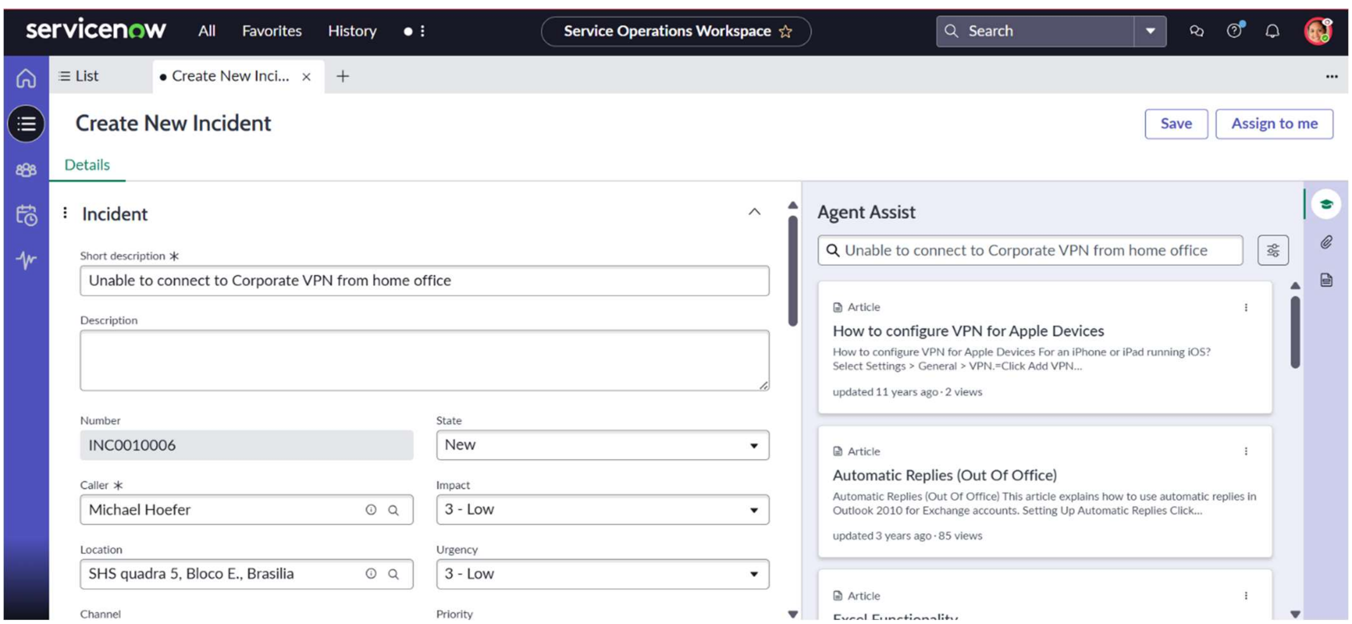
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Urgency
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Priority
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Unable to connect to Corporate VPN from home office
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How to configure VPN for Apple Devices
How to configure VPN for Apple Devices For an iPhone or iPad running iOS? Select Settings > General > VPN.=Click Add VPN...
updated 11 years ago · 2 views
Article
Automatic Replies (Out Of Office)
Automatic Replies (Out Of Office) This article explains how to use automatic replies in Outlook 2010 for Exchange accounts. Setting Up Automatic Replies Click...
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Article

Phase 4 – Incident Classification

Once the base incident record exists, it must be enriched with the data needed for accurate routing, prioritization, and reporting.

4.1 Updating Incident Details

The agent sets Category and Subcategory (Network > VPN) to describe the nature of the fault, and Urgency to reflect how time-sensitive the disruption is for the caller. Service and Service Offering are set to Remote Access and Corporate VPN, tying the record back to the CMDB structure created earlier.

The Configuration Item field identifies the specific infrastructure believed to be involved, and Work Notes are used to capture internal diagnostic detail — error messages, client versions, or troubleshooting already attempted — that supports whoever handles the ticket next.

Implementation Highlights

- Category / Subcategory and Urgency set
- Service, Service Offering, and Configuration Item linked
- Work Notes capture internal diagnostic detail

Phase 5 – Knowledge Integration

As soon as classification data is present on the incident, the workflow checks whether existing knowledge can resolve the issue before any further escalation is considered.

5.1 Agent Assist Verification

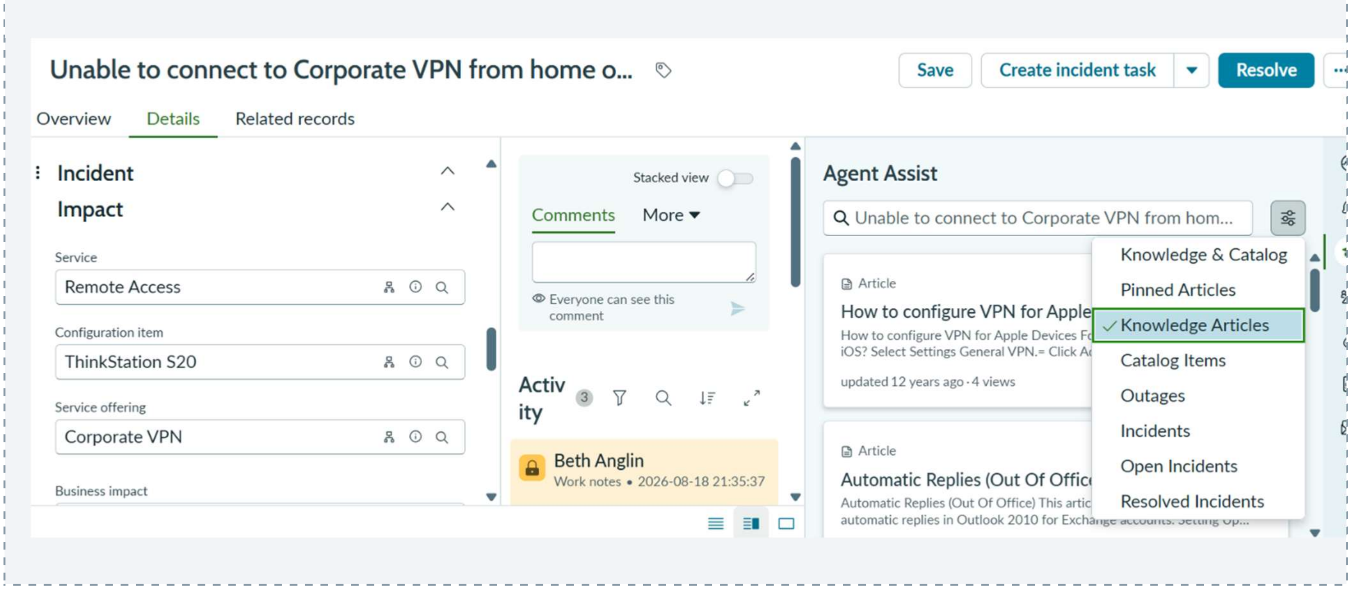
Agent Assist scans the Knowledge Base for articles matching the category, keywords, and CI on the incident, surfacing previously documented VPN fixes directly inside the incident form without a manual search.

The agent verifies the suggested article is genuinely relevant, attaches it to the incident, and records the outcome of applying it in Work Notes — whether it resolved the issue or not — so that context travels with the ticket regardless of outcome.

Implementation Highlights

- Agent Assist surfaces matching Knowledge Articles
- Relevance of the suggested article verified before use
- Article attached to the incident record
- Outcome of the attempted fix logged in Work Notes

Output



Phase 6 – Reassignment & Escalation

When the attached knowledge article does not resolve the issue, the incident is prepared for and moved to Level 2 support. This phase covers two steps: updating the Watch List, and performing the reassignment itself.

6.1 Watch List Update

Before reassigning ownership, the agent adds relevant colleagues to the Watch List so they receive updates on the incident without taking ownership of it, and uses the Work Notes List to loop in specific individuals — such as a network engineer — whose input may be needed.

This keeps stakeholders informed as the investigation continues and ensures the right people see updates the moment they are posted, without cluttering the ticket's primary ownership.

Implementation Highlights

- Watch List updated with relevant stakeholders
- Work Notes List used to loop in subject-matter experts
- Notifications configured to keep stakeholders current

6.2 Reassignment

The Assignment Group is changed from the Service Desk group to the appropriate Level 2 network/VPN support group, formally transferring ownership so the ticket appears in the correct team's work queue.

This transfer is fully logged on the incident's activity timeline, preserving a clear record of when and why ownership moved from first-line to second-line support.

Implementation Highlights

- Assignment Group changed to Level 2 network/VPN support
- Ownership transfer logged on the activity timeline
- Ticket appears in the correct team work queue

Phase 7 – Incident Tracking by Level 2

With ownership transferred, Level 2 support begins working the incident using the full context captured so far.

7.1 Investigation by Network Team

Level 2 engineer David Loo reviews the incident's full history — original description, classification, attached Knowledge Article, and prior Work Notes — before starting new investigation, avoiding duplicated troubleshooting.

He checks the Task SLA panel to understand how much time remains before a breach, then begins deeper diagnostic work on the Corporate VPN service, documenting each investigative step in Work Notes so the record remains a complete, chronological account.

Implementation Highlights

- Prior classification and Knowledge Article reviewed first
- Task SLA remaining time checked before investigation begins
- New diagnostic findings logged in Work Notes

Phase 8 – Emergency Change Request Creation

When investigation identifies a root cause that requires a production infrastructure change, that change is routed through formal Change Management rather than being applied informally.

8.1 Create Change

David identifies that the root cause involves the PowerEdge server hosting the VPN concentrator, which needs a configuration update outside standard change windows. An Emergency Change Request is raised, documenting the PowerEdge server as the affected Configuration Item, the justification for bypassing the normal schedule, and the planned implementation and back-out steps.

The related incident is set to On Hold with a reason of Awaiting Change while the change is pending, which pauses SLA clocks appropriately and communicates that resolution depends on the change being completed.

Implementation Highlights

- Emergency Change raised against the PowerEdge server CI
- Justification and implementation/back-out plan documented
- Incident set to On Hold – Awaiting Change
- Change record linked back to the parent incident

Phase 9 – Child Incident Creation

While the emergency change is in progress, additional related reports of the same disruption are linked to the original incident rather than investigated independently.

9.1 Create Child Incident

As further users report the same VPN symptom, their reports are created as child incidents linked to the original parent incident, letting Level 2 track the full scope of user impact from a single parent record.

Each child incident retains its own number for the reporting user's visibility, and resolving the parent automatically flags the linked children for review and closure, keeping the incident queue accurate.

Implementation Highlights

- Related VPN reports linked as child incidents
- Parent incident tracks full scope of user impact
- Each child keeps its own number for caller visibility

Phase 10 – Incident Resolution

Once the emergency change is implemented and service is confirmed restored, the incident is resolved. This phase covers two steps: documenting the cause, and documenting the resolution.

10.1 Add Cause

The Probable Cause field is completed to summarize the root cause identified during investigation — the VPN concentrator configuration on the PowerEdge server — in language precise enough for reporting and future reference.

Implementation Highlights

- Probable Cause documents the VPN concentrator configuration issue
- Cause is linked to the Configuration Item investigated

10.2 Add Resolution

David confirms with caller Michael Hoefer that Corporate VPN access has been restored, then completes the Resolution Notes field describing exactly what was changed and verified, in enough detail that another engineer could reproduce or reverse the fix if needed, before moving the incident to a resolved state.

Implementation Highlights

- Caller confirmation obtained before resolving
- Resolution Notes describe the exact corrective action taken
- Incident moved to resolved state

Phase 11 – Knowledge Creation

With the cause and fix clearly documented, the resolution is converted into reusable knowledge rather than being left inside a closed incident record.

11.1 Create Knowledge Article

A new Knowledge Article is drafted from the Probable Cause and Resolution Notes, restating the symptom, cause, and resolution steps in a self-contained, easy-to-follow format, and tagged with the same Category and CI information as the incident.

This tagging allows Agent Assist to surface the article automatically the next time a similar VPN issue is reported, directly closing the loop between incident handling and Knowledge Management.

Implementation Highlights

- Article drafted from Probable Cause and Resolution Notes
- Tagged to match the incident's Category and CI
- Submitted for review/publication in the Knowledge Base

Phase 12 – Final Validation

Before the incident and its associated records are considered complete, every linked piece of the workflow is checked for consistency.

12.1 Final Validation

The new Knowledge Article is checked to confirm it is properly attached to the parent incident and correctly categorized. All child incidents raised during the outage are reviewed to confirm they inherited the resolution details and closed in step with the parent.

The Task SLA record is reviewed end-to-end, including the time spent On Hold during the emergency change, to confirm SLA visibility and reporting reflect an accurate account of how the incident was handled.

Implementation Highlights

- Knowledge Article linkage to the incident verified
- All child incidents confirmed closed with the parent
- Task SLA timeline reviewed, including On Hold duration

Phase 13 – Testing & Deployment Validation

To confirm the workflow behaves correctly as a whole, a full test pass re-runs the scenario end-to-end across every integrated module.

13.1 Testing & Deployment

The scenario is re-created from incident creation through Emergency Change, child incident linkage, resolution, and knowledge publication, confirming each module correctly hands off to the next.

Testing specifically confirms Task SLA timers start, pause on Hold, and stop correctly; Agent Assist suggestions appear at classification; the Emergency Change correctly places the incident On Hold and later allows it to resume; and the new Knowledge Article becomes searchable immediately after publication.

Implementation Highlights

- End-to-end scenario re-run across all integrated modules
- SLA timer start/pause/stop behavior verified
- Agent Assist and Knowledge suggestion accuracy verified
- Emergency Change hold/resume behavior verified

Phase 14 – Conclusion

14.1 Conclusion

Walking through the Remote Access / Corporate VPN scenario from initial report to knowledge publication demonstrates a complete, ITIL-aligned incident lifecycle inside ServiceNow, touching Incident Management, CMDB, Knowledge Management, Change Management, Service Operations Workspace, and SLA tracking in a single connected flow.

Each phase in this report builds on the one before it: CMDB structure enables accurate classification, classification enables relevant knowledge suggestions, escalation preserves full diagnostic context, change control protects infrastructure changes, and resolution feeds directly back into the knowledge base for the next similar incident.

The result is a workflow that improves operational visibility, reduces manual effort and duplicated troubleshooting, supports faster resolution through knowledge reuse, and leaves a complete, auditable documentation trail for every incident handled through it.

Implementation Highlights

- Demonstrates a full, connected ITIL incident lifecycle in ServiceNow
- Each phase's output feeds directly into the next
- Improves visibility, reduces effort, and speeds resolution